



Week 2

Diversity in Organizations

Diversity, inclusion and quality decisions

People differ in visible traits, deeper values and work preferences. Quality systems must convert those differences into better learning, decision-making and service.

surface

deep

Based on Robbins & Judge, Organizational Behavior, 18th ed., Chapter 2

Designed for active, case-based postgraduate learning

Dr. Abdelmutalab Adam

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

Explain

Distinguish surface-level and deep-level diversity.

Analyze

Explain how discrimination and stereotype threat reduce organizational effectiveness.

Assess

Evaluate how biographical characteristics and abilities influence work decisions.

Apply

Use diversity concepts to diagnose a quality-related team problem.

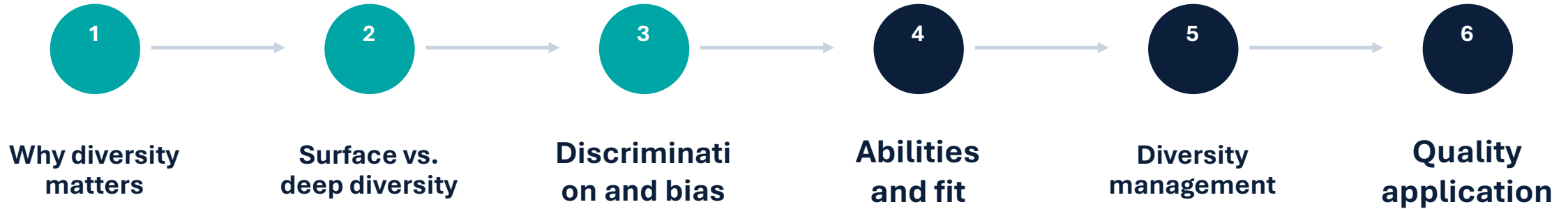
Design

Recommend practical diversity-management actions that support quality, fairness and inclusion.

Guiding question: How can diversity be managed so that it strengthens—not weakens—quality decisions and service outcomes?

Session Roadmap

A practical path from concepts to action.



Core idea: Diversity improves quality only when institutions reduce bias, create fair processes and convert different perspectives into better decisions.

Opening Case: Diverse Team, Unequal Voice

A postgraduate discussion starter

A university quality-improvement committee includes academic staff, administrative staff, IT staff, and student representatives. During meetings, senior members dominate discussion. Younger staff and students rarely speak. The team collects useful data, but decisions still reflect the assumptions of the loudest members. Complaints about student services remain high.

Discuss

- What types of diversity are present?
- What hidden differences may matter?
- What bias or status effects may exist?
- How might this influence quality decisions?

Key Insight

Diversity without inclusion can become symbolic. Quality teams need both varied perspectives and fair participation mechanisms.

Teaching Move

Ask learners to separate visible diversity, deep-level diversity, power/status dynamics and quality outcomes.

What Diversity Means in Organizations

Diversity is broader than demographic categories.

Diversity

Differences among people that may influence their experiences, relationships and contributions at work.

Quality lens

Different people notice different risks, needs, errors and opportunities for improvement.

Management challenge

Prevent differences from becoming stereotypes, exclusion, conflict or unfair decisions.

Diversity is not only “who is in the room.”

Inclusion is about whose knowledge is heard and used.

Quality improves when diverse perspectives are structured into decision processes.

Two Major Forms of Workplace Diversity

Surface-level and deep-level diversity influence groups differently over time.

Surface-level diversity

Easily perceived characteristics such as age, gender, race, ethnicity or visible disability. These traits may activate stereotypes, but do not necessarily reflect how people think or feel.

Deep-level diversity

Differences in values, personality and work preferences. These often become more important as people interact and learn about one another.

Instructional point: Do not assume that visible similarity means shared values—or that visible difference means incompatible work preferences.

The Diversity Iceberg

Visible traits are only the surface of workplace difference.

Visible / Surface

Age • Gender • Ethnicity • Visible disability

Most assumptions are made above this line.

Hidden / Deep

Values • Personality • Work preferences • Experience
• Family background • Beliefs • Learning styles

Quality implication

A diverse quality team needs structured dialogue to reveal deep-level knowledge before making decisions.

Discrimination Undermines Organizational Effectiveness

Bias can damage fairness, participation and quality performance.

Forms

Unfair exclusion, harassment, stereotyping, biased evaluation, unequal opportunities and inaccessible work design.

Behavioral effects

Lower trust, silence, withdrawal, stress, reduced commitment and defensive behavior.

Quality effects

Under-reporting problems, weak collaboration, poor service recovery, narrow decision-making and lost improvement ideas.

Quality principle: People who do not feel respected or safe are less likely to speak up about defects, risks or customer needs.

Stereotypes and Stereotype Threat

Bias affects both perception and performance.

Stereotype

A generalized belief about a group that may distort how an individual is judged.

Stereotype threat

The risk that people underperform or withdraw because they fear confirming a negative stereotype.

Managers may misread capability because they see the label before the person.
Employees may avoid contribution if they expect bias or ridicule.
Quality teams lose important data when members self-censor.

Move from labels to evidence-based evaluation.

Biographical Characteristics: Use Carefully

Observable characteristics can matter, but should not replace evidence.

Age

Avoid assumptions about learning, adaptability or productivity.

Gender

Evaluate work requirements and performance, not stereotypes.

Race & ethnicity

Build fair systems and prevent exclusion or biased judgment.

Disability

Focus on capability, accommodation and job fit.

Tenure

Experience may help, but it is not the same as effectiveness.

Managerial rule: Fair does not always mean identical. Fair means evidence-based, respectful and job-relevant.

Abilities and Job Fit

Diversity management includes aligning abilities with work requirements.

Intellectual abilities

Mental capabilities needed to perform cognitive activities such as reasoning, problem solving and decision making.

Physical abilities

Capabilities needed for tasks involving strength, stamina, coordination or sensory requirements.

Quality application

Define the quality-critical task before judging ability.

Use valid selection, training and accommodation practices.

Design work so that diverse capability becomes a resource, not a barrier.

Diversity in Quality Teams

Differences can improve decisions—if the team process supports learning.

Potential benefits

More information, broader customer understanding, better risk detection, creative solutions and stronger innovation.

Potential risks

Communication gaps, subgroup formation, conflict, status inequality, stereotyping and slower early coordination.

Process requirement

Psychological safety, clear roles, facilitation, evidence use and structured participation.

Diversity is an input. Inclusion and team learning are the processes that convert it into quality outcomes.

Managing Diversity Effectively

Diversity management must cross systems, not only training sessions.

Attract

Recruit from broader talent pools and remove unnecessary barriers.

Select

Use job-relevant criteria, structured assessment and bias checks.

Develop

Provide equitable access to learning, coaching and career opportunities.

Retain

Build respect, flexibility, safety and fair recognition.

Evaluate

Monitor outcomes by group, role and process—not only intentions.

Best practice: redesign processes so fairness is built into work—not dependent only on goodwill.

What Makes Diversity Programs Work?

Effective programs combine awareness, skill and system redesign.

Awareness

Help people notice assumptions, stereotypes and exclusion patterns.

Skill development

Practice inclusive communication, feedback, conflict handling and decision participation.

Accountability

Link inclusion to leadership behavior, process indicators and improvement goals.

Continuous effort

Avoid one-off training. Use ongoing learning, data monitoring and reinforcement.

Contact and collaboration

Increase meaningful contact across groups through real work, not symbolic events.

Linking Diversity to Total Quality Management

TQM depends on people seeing, sharing and improving work differently.

TQM Principle	Diversity Link	Quality Result
Customer focus	Understand varied user needs	Better service design
Employee involvement	Include frontline voices	More improvement ideas
Process approach	Reduce bias in handoffs	Fewer errors and delays
Evidence-based decisions	Use data, not stereotypes	Fairer and better choices
Continual improvement	Learn from difference	Innovation and adaptability

Mini Case: The Complaint Review Panel

A short case for concept application.

A service organization formed a complaint review panel. The panel includes managers from operations, quality, IT and customer service. However, all members have similar professional backgrounds and long tenure. They quickly agree on causes, usually blaming customers for incomplete requests. A new employee suggests that forms may be unclear for first-time users, but the idea is dismissed because “this is how we have always done it.” Complaints continue to rise.

Questions

1. What types of diversity are missing?
2. What stereotypes or assumptions appear?
3. How does deep-level diversity matter here?
4. What process change would improve the panel?
5. What quality indicator should be monitored?

Core lesson: A team can look coordinated and still be blind to customer needs if it lacks cognitive diversity and inclusive process.

In-Class Activity: Diversity-to-Quality Diagnostic Map

Small groups | 25 minutes

Scenario

A hospital patient-experience team wants to reduce complaints about unclear instructions. The team has clinical, administrative and patient representatives, but participation is uneven.

Task

1. Identify visible and hidden diversity.
2. Identify one bias or exclusion risk.
3. Map how this affects communication and service quality.
4. Recommend two inclusive team practices.
5. Select two indicators to monitor improvement.

Deliverable

One-page map: Diversity input → Team process → Quality outcome. Prepare a 2-minute explanation.

Debrief Questions

Use these prompts after the group activity.

- Which visible differences were easiest to notice?
- Which deep-level differences became important after discussion?
- What bias or assumption could distort the team's diagnosis?
- How can participation be structured so quiet voices are heard?
- What evidence would show that inclusion improved service quality?
- What practice should be adopted in every quality-improvement meeting?

Facilitator note: Push learners to distinguish diversity as a characteristic, inclusion as a process, and quality improvement as an outcome.

Knowledge Check

Answer individually, then compare with a partner.

1 Surface-level diversity includes easily perceived characteristics: True or False?

2 Deep-level diversity refers to differences in values, personality and work preferences: True or False?

3 Name one way discrimination can reduce quality performance.

4 Why should managers avoid relying on demographic assumptions?

5 Give one diversity-management action that supports fair quality decisions.

Week 2 Assignment: Inclusion and Quality Diagnostic Brief

Individual work | 700–900 words

Task

Select a real or familiar quality-related team or service process. Analyze how diversity, bias, inclusion or participation may influence quality outcomes.

Required sections

- Problem context and stakeholders
- Surface-level and deep-level diversity factors
- Bias, stereotype or exclusion risk
- Quality consequences
- Two practical interventions
- Two monitoring indicators

Assessment criteria

Conceptual accuracy 25% • Diagnostic depth 25% • Quality connection 20% • Feasibility 15% • Clarity and professionalism 15%

Rubric Snapshot

Full rubric is included in the assessment pack.

Criterion	Weight	Excellent evidence
Conceptual accuracy	25%	Correctly uses surface/deep diversity, discrimination and diversity management concepts.
Diagnostic depth	25%	Moves beyond description to explain mechanisms and evidence.
Quality connection	20%	Shows how behavior affects service, defects, safety, reliability or satisfaction.
Feasibility	15%	Recommendations are practical, ethical and measurable.
Professional writing	15%	Clear structure, concise language and no confidential data.

Key Takeaways

What students should retain after Week 2.

1 Diversity has surface-level and deep-level forms.

2 Visible differences can trigger stereotypes, but deeper values and preferences shape teamwork over time.

3 Discrimination and stereotype threat reduce trust, participation and effectiveness.

4 Ability should be evaluated in relation to job requirements and reasonable accommodations.

5 Diversity management must be systematic and ongoing.

6 Quality improves when different perspectives are included in evidence-based decisions.

Reference and Preparation for Next Session

Complete the Week 2 assignment and prepare for Week 3.

Primary reference

Robbins, S. P., & Judge, T. A. (2019). Organizational Behavior (18th ed.). Pearson. Chapter 2: Diversity in Organizations.

Prepare for Week 3

Read Chapter 3: Attitudes and Job Satisfaction. Identify one workplace factor that increases job satisfaction and one factor that reduces it.

Next week: Attitudes, Job Satisfaction and Employee Engagement — linking employee experience to service quality and performance.

Thank you